

## DivX HD enabled Blu-ray Player

Rovi and ASUS are working to launch DivX HD-enabled Blu-Ray devices

## Student's experiment in space

YouTube, Lenovo and NASA have come together to launch Youtube Space Lab for students between 14 to 18 years

which is very dust, scratch and fingerprint prone. As a consolation the front panel runs a LED strip which makes it a bit attractive and the bottom opens to house a 3.5-inch HDD. The ASUS O! Play Mini Plus has the same form factor and built as its predecessor the O! Play Mini, but this time with a very jazzy honeycomb like design on the top surface. The iOmega Screen-Play TV Link Dx has a rectan-



ASUS O! Play HDP R1

gular form factor with eye-catching curves and decent built quality, but it too has a glossy exterior that picks up smudges and scratches. The Seagate Go Flex TV and WD Live TV are the compact form factor players of the lot. While both have durable build, the Seagate breaks the cliché by having a matte exterior. Seagate's front panel opens to house a 2.5-inch HDD, but the housing is well disguised.

### Remote

iOmega stands out with its QWERTY keypad packed remote design. Though it

requires you to use both your hands to operate it, it helps make typing easy during searches or web browsing. What it lacks is a good key response and we would have liked if the keys were a bit bigger. The left D-pad which controls the fast forwarding/rewinding was a tad bit sensitive, which resulted in over fast forwarding/rewinding. The ASUS HDP R1 and Air both get identical remotes. It is very comfortable to hold and is well built. The key feedback is also quite good.

What we find amusing is only music media finds a dedicated key on remote. The ASUS HD2 and Mini Plus both get remotes with identical form factor, what differs is the placement, shape, size and count of keys. Mini Plus also gets an one touch Facebook share option and four colour keys for accessing media. Both remotes have a durable build and provide adequate key feedback.

### User interface

The ASUS HDP R1 and Air both run on the same UI, it is a simple and easy to use interface. It segregates files according to the type of media it belongs to. It has a UI which imitates a File Explorer for mapping connected devices (viz. Pendrive, HDD), which makes it difficult to search for a particular file incase you have a huge collec-

tion. The HD 2 on the other hand gets the upgrade from its previous UI and gets a different look. The UI now looks much better, more importantly the device now catalogs all kinds of media as opposed to cataloging only music media. The WD TV Live Hub has the best UI, it is very rich in terms of looks and is extremely easy to use. The iOmega has a XMB style UI, which is extremely easy to use but the aesthetics are not meant to impress.

### Performance

The ASUS HDP R1 completely blew us away with its performance in terms of sharpness and detailing but disappointed us with its colour reproduction and it failed in playing certain .flv files even though it claimed to support the format. On the other hand the ASUS Air gave good colour reproduction but lacked sharpness and crispness. The WD Live TV and iOmega Link DX delivered decent performance with upconverting of files but lacked at certain places. The HD 2 delivered a poor performance, we noticed a lot of noise and colour banding even after upscaling. It also failed to recognise a few of the .flv files we tried during the test. Of the lot the ASUS O! Play Mini Plus delivered good overall performance. We faced a lot of problems with the Seagate Go Flex TV viz. if the player was left idle for a while, it hanged. The

rewind was at times faulty with the video directly going back to the starting point.

### Winner

For its excellent upscaling ability, crisp and sharp videos and topping our performance charts the ASUS

O! Play HDP R1 won the Best Performer. Further, for being offered at a very competitive price it also wins our Best Buy award.

### High-end

We had four players in this category. We received two devices from iOmega and one each from ASUS and Western Digital.

### Build and design

The WD TV Live Hub media center comes as an update to the WD Live TV and sports a slimmer form factor and isn't quite heavy inspite of the presence of a 1 TB HDD. The device is extremely well built and sturdy. The player has a metallic matte finish on the top, whilst a glossy strip runs on the sides. The ASUS O! Play Gallery entirely borrows its design and built from the ASUS HD 2, while adding iPod and iPhone connectivity. It too houses a 3.5 inch HDD slot at the bottom. iOmega Screenplay DX 1 TB is an oversized version of the iOmega TV link DX with an inbuilt 1 TB HDD. The 1 TB HDD makes the media player quite bulky. The device is absolutely rock solid in terms of its build. On the other hand, the iOmega Screenplay MX 1 TB looks like a super-sized iOmega TV link Mx with a few more curves. It also gets an inbuilt 1 TB HDD, which makes it quite bulky. The Screen Play MX too is cased in an aluminum exterior and by far has the best build quality.

### Remote

The remote bundled with WD Live TV Hub is well built and gives adequate key feedback. The remote comes with four colour keys that can be customised to access certain media. The iOmega Screenplay MX gets the same remote as the iOmega TV link MX. Though the remote is

#### Contact sheet

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